

How asylum works in France.

What the official websites explain — and what they will never tell you.

NOTE ON THIS GUIDE

This guide is dedicated specifically to the asylum process. Sur la bonne voie is addressed to all people who wish to integrate in France — regardless of their status. Other guides cover residence permits, work, housing, and everyday life in France.

This guide follows the official process step by step. For each step, we add what we learned by living it ourselves — the things nobody tells you, which make all the difference.

01

Registration at the prefecture

From your arrival

Your first step is to register at the nearest prefecture. In large cities, **SPADA operators (Forum Réfugiés and others)** can assist you. During registration: fingerprinting, civil status, family situation. You will receive an **attestation de demande d'asile (ADA)** — valid for 6 months, renewable.

WHAT NOBODY TELLS YOU

SPADA offices are often overwhelmed — make an appointment as early as possible and follow up regularly. **If you don't speak French yet, that is your absolute top priority — even before starting the process.** Every interaction with the administration will be easier — and more favorable — if you make the effort to speak their language.

→ ofpra.gouv.fr — official website

02

OFII and housing

After registration

The OFII will offer you housing in a CADA — often in a different region. If you accept, you receive full support. If you refuse, **all OFII financial assistance is cut off.**

THINK CAREFULLY BEFORE REFUSING

We refused a housing offer in Lille to stay in Ardeche. It was our choice and we own it — but it meant losing all OFII financial support. If you refuse, you must have a concrete plan to cover your own needs.

03

The OFPRA file — your personal account

21 days to submit

You will receive a file to complete and send to the OFPRA by **registered mail** within 21 days. The central piece: your personal account — approximately 60 lines. You may add extra pages. Attach all your identity documents and evidence.

THE MOST IMPORTANT THING OF ALL

Get help writing your account. It must be clear to a French OFPRA officer — not just to you. Automatic translators often produce confused French. Think about how your situation fits the protected frameworks: women's rights, religious persecution, homophobia, violence against children. **You can send copies of your identity documents** — originals are not required. Nobody tells you this.

EVIDENCE IS EVERYTHING

Even if you carry the scars — without a document proving it, it is very hard to make your case. From your country of origin if possible: file complaints, keep all medical documents, all written testimonies.

04

The OFPRA interview

Approximately 3 months after submission

You will be summoned for an interview with an OFPRA officer. The officer will verify the consistency of your account, ask precise questions — sometimes destabilizing ones. The final decision depends largely on this interview.

WHAT NOBODY TELLS YOU

OFPRA officers are human beings — they can have biases and bad days. **Don't be afraid of them.** They will put pressure on you to test your consistency. If the officer rephrases something you did not say, **correct them immediately and calmly.** Your credibility is built in these moments. Your goal is to make a potential rejection absolutely unjustifiable.

05

The decision — and the appeal

3 months after the interview — then up to 1 year of appeals

In case of refusal, you have **30 days to appeal to the CNDA**. If the CNDA confirms the refusal, other options exist: the administrative tribunal, a request for an exceptional residence permit. The government covers legal costs through **aide juridictionnelle** — you are entitled to a free lawyer.

WHAT NOBODY TELLS YOU ABOUT COURT-APPOINTED LAWYERS

The aide juridictionnelle is real and it is your right. But here is the reality: you will wait **approximately 1 month for the CNDA appeal, and up to 6 months for the administrative tribunal** — not because it is complex, but because the lawyer waits to be sure the State will pay before genuinely working on your case. In most cases, **you will do 90% of the work yourself** — gathering evidence, writing your argument, documenting your integration. Know this from the start and get ahead of it.

DEADLINES ARE SHORT — ACT IMMEDIATELY

From the moment you receive a refusal: contact an association or a lawyer **the same day**. 30 days pass very quickly. Keep learning French, building your network, documenting your integration. Every piece of evidence

you accumulate strengthens your file.

→ cnda.fr — Cour Nationale du Droit d'Asile

What nobody tells you — but that changes everything.

Throughout the entire process:

- > French is your master key. Every door opens more easily with it — administration, work, friendships, housing. Nothing matters more.
- > Contact your prefecture by email from day one. Show that you exist, that you want to integrate. Don't be an anonymous file — be a person.
- > Go out. Talk to people. Social connection is your most powerful integration tool — and no one can take it from you.
- > Private housing is possible even without papers. The social network you build opens doors that the administration cannot open.
- > Look for work right now. Having an employer ready to sign a contract at the time of your decision can change everything.

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